

Project PrEP Health Talks

Audiences

Health talks take place in community hotspots, facilities, schools, and colleges where Project PrEP teams provide sexual and reproductive health (SRH) and HIV prevention services to adolescent girls and young women (AGYW). Health talks take place while people are waiting for service delivery and should last 15-20 minutes.

Purpose (objectives) of health talks:

Share information about the services Project PrEP offers, especially oral PrEP – note that we are no longer recruiting new people for the PrEP ring or the PrEP injection – only people who are already enrolled in the Project PrEP research study can continue with these methods or re-initiate on these methods.

We want community members and potential end-users to know what, where, why, and how we offer our services!

THESE CARDS ARE FOR HEALTH TALKS ONLY, dialogue cue cards are different.

Welcome and introduction!



- As you approach your audience, make sure you are in the right mindset.
- You are excited to tell people about Project PrEP and the services we are providing in their community.



Attitude is everything!

- Make sure to greet your audience in your own special way, be warm, outgoing and friendly.
- People will love listening to you. Remember to introduce yourself!

Project PrEP / Wits RHI: Who are we?



health

Department:
Health
REPUBLIC OF SOUTH AFRICA

Project PrEP is part of an organisation called Wits RHI and we work closely with South Africa's National Department of Health (NDOH). In this clinic (or from our mobile clinic), we provide contraception, HIV prevention and STI screening and treatment to girls and young women.



PrEP is a type of medication that an HIV-negative person can take to PREVENT HIV. This means if an HIV-negative person is using PrEP and they come into contact with HIV, they will most likely NOT be infected.

Girls and young women and HIV



Before we go further, I first want to ask whether anyone knows how many adolescent girls and young women are newly infected with HIV every week in South Africa.



Answer: Almost 2 000 adolescent girls and young women are infected with the virus every week in South Africa.



This means that HIV is still a real public health crisis in South Africa; we know that every two minutes, a South African is newly infected with HIV. As communities, parents, partners, young people and leaders, we have to come together to play our part. We cannot allow this virus to impact our children's children.

Oral PrEP



Oral PrEP: Oral PrEP is a daily pill that a person takes to prevent HIV infection. But you don't have to take it for the rest of your life, only when you are most worried about HIV.

- It works really well! It is **more than 90% successful** at preventing HIV.
- If you don't want people to know that you are using PrEP, **you can hide the pills** - it's your choice whether you tell people you are using PrEP or not.
- This method prevents HIV **all over your body**; it doesn't matter if you are having vaginal sex, anal sex, maybe injecting drugs and sharing needles or being exposed to blood.
- And, people who are **pregnant or breastfeeding** can use it too. It is safe for you and your baby.
- It is also a great HIV prevention method for people whose **partner is living with HIV**.
- Oral PrEP has some **side effects**, just like every medication has some side effects, even Disprin or Panado! Some people, about 2 out of every 10 people, report that they might get a bad headache, or perhaps feel a bit tired, maybe even feel somewhat nauseous or experience a bit of diarrhoea. This does not happen to everyone, and these side effects will go away. Your nurse will also help you to overcome these side effects, you are not alone!

What does PrEP not do?



- Oral PrEP **does not prevent other STIs or pregnancy**; you can, however, use it with any other medication and with your family planning.
- And, **PrEP is NOT PEP!** It will not work if you take or use it after you've come into contact with HIV, like when the condom bursts or you forget to use a condom.



So, what do you have to do if you want to start oral PrEP?

- Test negative for HIV.
- Some blood draws depending on the method you want.
- Professional nurse will explain the medication and the process to you before you get your first supply of pills or ring, or your first injection.

Where does Project PrEP provide services?

Project PrEP provides services in clinics, through mobile clinics in communities, at tertiary institutions, schools and colleges. You can ask any of us for more details OR



Send us a WhatsApp message on **065 869 8031**.

Project PrEP's study on new methods



Remember that oral PrEP (the pills) are available to everyone.

In 2023 and 2024, Wits RHI started a research study by providing the PrEP ring and PrEP injection to people who consented to being part of the research study.

RIGHT NOW, the PrEP ring and PrEP injection are only available to people who are already part of this research study – we are no longer asking new people to join this study. This means, only people who are part of this study can continue with the PrEP ring or PrEP injection, or re-initiate on one of these methods.

From August 2023 to April 2024, we offered a choice between the PrEP ring and oral PrEP in Mthatha, Gqeberha, and Tshwane, and 2,738 people participated in this phase of the study, including 126 women in discussions.

And what did we find: most women chose oral PrEP, while a few selected the PrEP ring, citing safety and lifestyle fit as key factors. Participants valued the educational materials, demonstrations, and healthcare provider support.

From April to November 2024, we added the PrEP injection, and 3,784 people participated. Most chose the injection and returned for their next dose, indicating strong interest and commitment to this HIV prevention method.

Why did we do this study?



- This research helps us to find out how people feel about the PrEP ring or PrEP injection and how they want the NDOH and government to provide and promote these methods to people.
- VERY IMPORTANT: Remember that when the study ends, you might not be able to get the ring or injection while the study results are being looked at, but you will still be able to get oral PrEP!

Where in South Africa is this study taking place?

- Project PrEP is running this study in two provinces in South Africa, in the Eastern Cape and Gauteng.

You are important – we need your support



- We can't make a difference without you!
We are because you are!
- We're asking you to please talk to us if you have any questions or concerns!
- And if you are as passionate about stopping the spread of HIV, stopping STIs and preventing unintended pregnancies, please tell the people in your life (your friends, your family) about the work we are doing here. **Encourage them to come to us to talk about the services we provide.**

Thank you for listening. Thank you to all of you for listening to me; if you have any questions or worries, please come talk to me or any of our staff members at the mobile clinic or the YouthZone Clinic at this facility.

Go well!